LEVEL-ONE PLAYTEST RULEBOOK

Six starting classes | Four monsters | Universal three-action combat | Tactical square-grid play

Consolidated working edition - Prepared from the collaboratively established playtest rules. Approved rules are stated directly; operational defaults and unresolved specifications are explicitly marked so they cannot be mistaken for adopted design choices.

This is the Stage 1 text-only rules reference. Illustrated character sheets and a two-sided table reference are later deliverables, after this rulebook is reviewed.

Reader key

- **Established:** A rule the designer expressly approved.
- **Provisional:** A prior test statistic or rule proposal retained to make a playtest possible.
- **Open:** A question that still needs a designer decision; apply an agreed session ruling and record it.

1 | Playtest scope and philosophy

Science-fantasy tabletop RPG with technology, magic, altered biology, and cosmic-horror influences. Character creation should remain accessible; universal actions allow a party of any class composition to improvise solutions. No class is mandatory for basic recovery. Level-one combat uses six playable classes and four monsters. Future branching specializations, deeper progression, and resource systems are outside this build.

1.1 Starting character framework

Element	Rule
Attributes	Might, Insight, Presence. Level-one distribution: +1, +0, -1 in any order; each class has a recommended arrangement.
Skills	Athletics, Mobility, Stealth, Influence, Technology, Medicine, Knowledge, Survival, Occult, Piloting.
Skill ranks	Untrained +0; Familiar +1; Trained +2; Expert +3; Master +4; Elite +5 (later levels not part of current build).
Starting training	One class-designated signature skill automatically Trained (+2). Provisional full distribution: 2 Trained, 2 Familiar, 6 Untrained, meaning one other Trained and two Familiar picks.
Skill checks	Choose an attribute appropriate to the actual approach; no rigid attribute-to-skill lock. Roll 2d10 + attribute + training against 12.
Awareness	An always-available Presence-based check, untrainable; +0 innate bonus at level 1 (higher-level progression deferred).
Speed	All six players: 6 squares per Move action.
Health	Tracked separately from attribute values for this playtest.

1.2 Signature skills

Class	Attribute recommendation	Signature skill
Soldier	Might +1 / Insight 0 / Presence -1	Athletics +2
Mutant	Might +1 / Insight -1 / Presence 0	Mobility +2
Medic	Might -1 / Insight +1 / Presence 0	Medicine +2
Influencer	Might 0 / Insight -1 / Presence +1	Influence +2
Magi	Might -1 / Insight 0 / Presence +1	Occult +2
Engineer	Might 0 / Insight +1 / Presence -1	Technology +2

2 | Core dice and critical results

Universal target: Roll two separate ten-sided dice (1-10 each), sum them, add relevant modifiers, and meet or exceed Target 12. Attacks and ordinary checks use the same target. No general enemy armor-class or defense target increases.

Doubles: Matching d10 faces on a successful check count as a critical success. Matching faces on a failed check count as a critical failure. A normal failure simply fails unless an ability says otherwise.

Critical attack choice: On a successful critical attack choose to double the damage rolled OR deal normal damage and apply an eligible standard Opening effect without the extra Opening action/check. This does not automatically grant the enhanced critical-Opening version.

Critical failure, general: The GM may choose a minor narrative complication or use a tactical complication tied to an Opening; the two suggested tables appear in section 4. Opening-specific critical results are fixed in section 4.

Critical healing doubles the rolled healing value. Specific nondice Medic payload critical values are listed on its class sheet. Automatic effects such as Arcane Ward do not roll and cannot critically succeed.

3 | Turn sequence and universal actions

Group initiative: At the start of every round, roll one d10 for the player team and one for the opposing team. Higher die chooses who activates first; reroll ties. Each team activates its participants in a chosen order, each resolving its own complete turn, then the other team acts. Initiative is rolled afresh each round, so consecutive team phases are possible at round boundaries.

Action	Cost / restriction	Effect
Attack	1 action; maximum 2 per character turn	Weapon, spell, or payload attack. No penalty for the second Attack.
Move	1 action; repeatable	Move up to Speed in squares.
Guard	1 action; once per turn	Protect self or adjacent ally against next successful hit: subtract 2 damage.
Create an Opening	1 action; one attempt per turn	2d10 check vs 12; select one of four effects.
Interact	1 action for simple tasks	Open a door, press button, pick up object; difficult tasks may take more actions/checks.
Use an Ability	Cost stated by ability; no universal usage cap	Activate a class technique, gadget, or spell; individual limitations apply.
Get Back in the Fight	1 action; adjacency required	Return a Downed ally to 1 HP automatically; no roll.

Guard duration: Expires after the opposing team's next activation phase if not triggered. Armor DR and Guard stack; multiple Guards do not stack on one protected character. Guard requires no roll.

Revival example: An Influencer may Rally one Downed ally within 6 squares, Move beside another Downed ally, then use Get Back in the Fight; this spends all three actions. Rally itself is once per Influencer turn.

4 | Openings and critical tables

Choose the intended Opening before the setup roll. Spend one action and roll against 12 with a context-appropriate modifier. The setup method must plausibly reach the target: use its weapon/ability range, with normal line of sight where needed. Neither the setup character nor the follow-up ally must be adjacent merely because this is an Opening. A follow-up ally must still obey their own action's reach/range. One Opening attempt per character turn, and only one active pending Opening on a target at a time. No extra free attacks or chained actions.

Opening	Ordinary success	Critical success	Critical failure
Off Balance	Target spends 1 action to regain balance on its next turn.	Target spends 2 actions recovering.	You become Off Balance instead.
Distracted	Next allied attack against target gains +2 to hit.	Next 2 allied attacks gain +2 to hit.	Enemy gains +2 to hit you with its next attack.
Exposed	Next successful allied attack deals +2 damage.	Next successful allied attack deals +4 and ignores 1 DR.	Next successful enemy attack against you deals +2 damage.
Clear Path	Reposition target 1 square from current location in any direction to valid empty square.	Reposition target up to 2 squares to valid empty destination.	Target repositions you 1 square into a valid empty square.

Ordinary failed Opening: No effect. **Off Balance:** On affected character's next turn, cannot Move, Attack, or Create an Opening until its required recovery action(s) are spent; applies to players and monsters. **Clear Path:** resolves immediately, with no need to end adjacent to the creator. **Distracted / Exposed:** expire after the next allied team activation phase if unused (working timing convention).

4.1 Optional GM critical-failure tables for other checks

d4	Tactical complication
1	Off Balance: must use an action to recover next turn.
2	Distracted: next enemy attack against you gets +2 to hit.
3	Exposed: next successful enemy attack against you deals +2 damage.
4	Clear Path reversal: an enemy repositions you 1 valid square.

d6	Narrative complication (GM contextualizes)
1	Minor slip or stumble.
2	Equipment momentarily misbehaves.
3	Attract unwanted attention.
4	Minor environmental disturbance.
5	Tactical miscommunication.
6	Unexpected minor complication fitting the scene.

The designer approved the hybrid option: GM may select a fitting consequence or roll on these tables. The specific four Opening success/failure entries above come from the previously supplied Opening reference graphic, with the later-approved Clear Path distance revision.

5 | Movement, positioning, cover and damage

Squares: Every orthogonal or diagonal step costs one square. Measure distance by the fewest orthogonal/diagonal steps on an otherwise open grid (the greater axis offset). All eight surrounding squares are adjacent. Basic melee reach = 1 square; extended reach = 2 squares. Standard range labels: Close 1, Medium 6, Long 10 squares. Specific equipment ranges override these labels.

Occupancy: Allies can pass through one another's squares but cannot end their movement in any occupied square. Monsters can pass through allied monsters. Opponent-occupied squares cannot normally be passed through (playtest working assumption). Leaving an enemy's adjacency never provokes a universal opportunity attack; only a specific ability could create such an exception.

Line of sight: A fully blocking obstacle prevents direct ranged targeting. Partial cover cancels up to +2 of the attacker's positive attack-roll bonuses; Target 12 never changes. Apply equally to both sides. For attacks that originate from a remote companion, assess line of sight from the companion's position.

General DR: Flat, not separated by damage type in this level-one build. Subtract DR and effects such as Guard from calculated damage, floor final damage at 0. Engineer Disruptor permits attacks to ignore 1 point of DR while its debuff lasts. Ongoing poison ticks ignore ordinary DR.

Damage order: Resolve hit and damage, including additive/doubled damage; apply applicable DR/Guard; expend temporary HP first; then reduce normal HP. Temporary HP sources do not add together: keep the larger current pool, never the sum. Healing cannot exceed maximum normal HP.

Downed: At 0 HP, character loses further turns until returned to positive HP. No death saves or automatic permanent death. A successful Restorative Shot or Rally can revive at range; Get Back in the Fight revives from adjacency. On a party victory, Downed allies recover to 1 HP. On total defeat, encounter is lost with scenario-dependent consequences, not automatic permanent death.

6 | Character stat blocks: Soldier and Mutant

6.1 SOLDIER | Level 1

Stat	Value
HP / Speed	18 HP / Speed 6
Attributes	Might +1; Insight +0; Presence -1
Signature	Athletics Trained (+2)
Long Rifle	Attack +3; damage 1d6; range 8; magazine 6; Reload 1 action
Stun Baton	Attack +3; damage 1d6+1; reach 1; no extra stun mechanics
Aim	1 Use an Ability action: next weapon attack gets +1 to hit and +1 damage if successful; expires end of current turn (working timing).
Shields Up	1 Use an Ability action after Guard: existing Guard prevents 3 total damage rather than 2. Expires when Guard ends.
Survival	18 HP, universal Guard and Get Back in the Fight; no starting armor in playtest.

6.2 MUTANT | Level 1

Stat	Value
HP / Speed	16 HP / Speed 6 (starting HP provisional)
Attributes	Might +1; Insight -1; Presence 0
Signature	Mobility Trained (+2)
Melee mutation	Attack +3; damage 1d6+1; reach 1 (working damage)
Neural Pulse	Attack +3; damage 1d6; range 6
Biological Overdrive	1 Use an Ability action; once per encounter; lasts 4 of the Mutant's turns, including activation turn. Choose Muscular, Neural, or Cellular.
Muscular mode	+2 melee damage; +1 movement Speed while active (working effect).
Neural mode	+2 Neural Pulse damage and modest neural/telekinetic boost while active (working effect).
Cellular mode	At start of each of the Mutant's turns while active gain/refresh 2 temporary HP, up to 4 temporary HP.
Mode switching	At most once per turn; costs no action but burns one additional remaining Overdrive turn; new mode takes effect immediately. Existing temporary HP persist under normal rules.
Noncombat	Minor psychic/telepathic and telekinetic expressions; distinctive visible but potentially concealable mutations. Exact scope to be adjudicated for playtest.

7 | Character stat blocks: Medic and Influencer

7.1 MEDIC | Level 1

Stat	Value
HP / Speed / attributes	16 HP; Speed 6; Might -1 / Insight +1 / Presence 0
Signature	Medicine Trained (+2)
Bio-Rifle	Attack +3; range 6; 8 payload shots; Reload 1 action
Compact Injector	Attack +3; melee reach 1; 2 payload shots; Reload 1 action; separate magazine
Payload rules	All four are Attack actions, maximum 2 attacks per turn; choose payload before roll; spend one shot regardless of outcome; roll 2d10 +3 vs 12, including for healing/self-targeting.
Restorative	Success: restore 1d6 HP, including revival at 0; critical: double healing roll.
Toxic	Success: 2 poison damage at beginning of target's next 2 turns; ignores DR; reapplication refreshes, never stacks. Critical: 4 each turn for same 2 turns.
Caustic	Success: deal 1d6 damage; critical: double rolled damage.
Adrenaline	Success: +2 Speed to all Move actions until end of recipient's next turn; critical: +4 Speed for same duration; no extra actions; does not stack.
Supplies	Refill magazines with one action each; replacement ammunition supply is not tracked.

7.2 INFLUENCER | Level 1

Stat	Value
HP / Speed / attributes	16 HP (provisional); Speed 6; Might 0 / Insight -1 / Presence +1
Signature	Influence Trained (+2)
Sidearm	Attack +2; damage 1d6; range 6; magazine 6; Reload 1 action (weapon values provisional)
Light melee weapon	Attack +2; damage 1d4; reach 1 (provisional)
Encourage	1 Use an Ability action; choose self or ally within 6 squares; recipient adds +1 to ANY one chosen 2d10 roll during their turn, declared before rolling. Applies to Opening attempts. Expires end of recipient's next turn.
Read the Situation	1 Use an Ability action; observe target within 6 squares; +2 to Influencer's own one Opening attempt against that creature. Declare use before the check; use-it-or-lose-it timing as Encourage.
Rally	1 Use an Ability action; once per Influencer turn; range 6. Normal: grant 2 nonstacking temporary HP plus +1 to one Opening check while Rally protection remains. OR, for a Downed target: restore 1 actual HP instead, without temporary HP/Opening bonus. No check.
Recovery synergy	May Rally a distant Downed ally and separately Move + Get Back in the Fight for an adjacent Downed ally within the same turn if action budget allows.

8 | Character stat blocks: Magi and Engineer

8.1 MAGI | Level 1

Stat	Value
HP / Speed / attributes	14 HP; Speed 6; Might -1 / Insight 0 / Presence +1
Signature	Occult Trained (+2)
Spell attacks	+3 vs Target 12; offensive spells count as Attack actions, maximum 2 per turn
Arcane Bolt	1 Attack; at will; 1d8 magical damage; range 6
Overcharged Bolt	1 Attack; once per encounter; 2d8 damage; range 6; use consumed on miss as well as hit
Force Wave	1 Attack; at will; 1d4 damage and push target 2 valid squares away; range 4; damage can double on critical
Arcane Ward	1 Use an Ability action; at will but once per Magi turn; automatic 3 temporary HP to self/ally within 6 squares; refreshes instead of stacking; no check, thus no critical Ward
Minor Sorcery	1 Use an Ability action; at will; small illusions, flashes, harmless light, unattended-object manipulation, remote simple interaction; combat applications handled contextually, with rolls for uncertain or opposed acts; range 6 provisional
Melee option	Simple 1d4 melee weapon, reach 1 (provisional)

8.2 ENGINEER | Level 1

Stat	Value
HP / Speed / attributes	16 HP (provisional); Speed 6; Might 0 / Insight +1 / Presence -1
Signature	Technology Trained (+2)
Modified Carbine	Attack +2; 1d6 damage; range 6; magazine 6; Reload 1 action
Modes	Overclocked: +2 successful-hit damage. Stabilized: +1 accuracy (attack +3). Disruptor: successful hit makes all allied attacks ignore 1 DR on target until end of current allied activation phase; effects do not stack.
Jury-Rig	1 Use an Ability action to activate/change carbine mode automatically, or enhance technological gear of self/adjacent ally (next qualifying action: +1 to hit, +1 damage, +2 range, or +1 on next Guard). Improvised/difficult applications require an appropriate check.
Mode cycle	A carbine mode lasts at most 2 consecutive rounds; changing modes via Jury-Rig action in time resets cycle. If third consecutive round arrives without change, bonus ceases and carbine falls back to ordinary 1d6 until serviced (see malfunction note).
Critical Jury-Rig failure	If a rolled, improvised/difficult modification involving the carbine critically fails, entire weapon becomes unusable until a 1-action Maintenance; only after repair may it fire or be modified.
Diagnostic Scanner	1 Use an Ability action; identify technological malfunction, faults, weak points, modifications; routine diagnostics automatic, defended/hidden complexity requires appropriate check.

Stat	Value
Signal Scrambler	1 Use an Ability action; disrupt remote signals/communications, sensors, or electronic controls; contested systems require Technology check. Range/duration contextual (6-square baseline proposed).
AI Companion	10 HP; Speed 6; starts following Engineer until commanded. 1 Engineer action orders companion to Move, Interact, scout, scan, or Create an Opening. No independent actions, attacks, or Guards. Can operate anywhere on map with intact remote communication. Uses Engineer's applicable check bonus. At 0 HP is Disabled; automatic repair outside combat.
Melee option	Compact engineering tool +2, 1d4 damage, reach 1 (provisional).

Engineer carbine normal overdue-mode malfunction and the severe critical-failure shutdown are separate. Whether ordinary overdue malfunction needs a separate Maintenance action versus simply Jury-Rigging a new mode is a playtest wording decision recorded in the final open-issues appendix.

9 | Monster stat blocks

9.1 Void Scavenger | melee swarm creature

HP	Speed	DR	Attack	Trait
7	5 (provisional)	0	Claws +1; 1d4; reach 1	Pack Hunter: +1 damage when another allied monster is adjacent to the target.

9.2 Ironhide Brute | armored melee threat

HP	Speed	DR	Attack	Trait
22	3	2	Slam +2; 1d8; reach 1	Bulldoze: on successful Slam, may push target 1 square to a valid empty square.

9.3 Spinecaster | mobile ranged threat

HP	Speed	DR	Attack	Trait
10	4 (provisional)	0	Quills +2; 1d6; range 6	No separate numerical feature yet; uses ranged attacks, movement, and standard universal actions.

9.4 Null Warden | biomechanical boss

Stat	Value
HP / Speed / DR	40 HP / 4 squares / flat DR 2
Actions	3 per turn, max 2 Attacks, once-per-turn Shockwave
Crushing Limb	Attack +3; 1d8+2 damage; reach 1
Null Pulse	Attack +2; 1d6 damage; range 6
Shockwave	1 Attack; +2 roll separately against each creature within 2 squares; success deals 1d4 damage and pushes 2 valid squares; includes other monsters, excludes Warden itself.
Reactive Plating	Flat DR 2; subject to ordinary Disruptor interactions.
Control Core	Spend 1 action and pass appropriate 2d10 + modifier vs Target 12; no mandatory class. On success choose: (a) Warden cannot use Shockwave until end of its next turn, OR (b) reduce Warden DR by 1 until end of its next turn.

All monsters have 3 actions, the maximum-two-attacks rule, access to standard actions when feasible, and no general attacks of opportunity. Reaching zero HP defeats/removes the monster for encounter purposes.

10 | Encounter setups and table procedure

Test	Player roster	Opposition	Main question
1	1 class	1 Void Scavenger	Basic turn, hit chance, survivability
2	2 classes	2 Scavengers	Opening creation, follow-up and Pack Hunter
3	3 classes	Ironhide Brute	Armor, Guard, Disruptor and Bulldoze
4	3 classes	Spinecaster + Scavenger	Range, chase, cover and team action economy
5	All 6 classes	Solo Null Warden	Boss survivability versus 18 player actions
6	All 6 classes	Null Warden + 2 Scavengers	Mixed boss battle, allied monster friendly fire

Before play, place units on a square grid; note obstacles and cover; establish ranges. Roll initiative each round. Players choose intra-team character activation order and resolve each full turn before the next activation. Record rounds, successful attacks, total damage/HP remaining, Overdrive use, ammo/reloads, Guard results, Openings, revival, and whether unique class powers actually mattered.

The encounter ends at the GM's scenario-appropriate endpoint. Encounter-limited abilities refresh automatically between encounters. A fully Downed party loses with consequences determined by the scenario, not automatic permanent death.

11 | Playtest examples

11.1 Combined team damage

Engineer activates Disruptor mode with Jury-Rig (1 action), then hits the Ironhide Brute (+2, 1d6). Until the player team's phase ends, allied attacks against that Brute ignore 1 of its 2 DR. The Engineer benefits, and subsequent Soldier or Mutant hits benefit. Disruptor does not permanently lower the Brute's DR.

11.2 A critical Opening

Influencer spends 1 action on Read the Situation, then 1 action to attempt Exposed on a target, adding +2 to their own Opening check. Successful doubles make it a critical Opening. The next successful allied attack gains +4 damage and ignores 1 DR. If the Opening check instead fails on matching dice, the next successful enemy attack against the Influencer deals +2 damage.

11.3 Rescue without a Medic

An Influencer spends one action using Rally on a Downed Soldier six squares away, returning the Soldier to 1 HP. The Influencer then Moves beside a second Downed ally and spends the third action on Get Back in the Fight, returning that ally to 1 HP. Rally is used only once. Neither rescue grants bonus actions.

11.4 Overdrive resource management

The Mutant activates Cellular Overdrive on their first turn (turn 1 of 4). On turn 2 they may freely switch once to Muscular, immediately reducing total remaining duration by one additional turn. Temporary HP previously granted by Cellular persists until lost or superseded by a new higher temporary-HP pool.

12 | Open issues and explicit playtest assumptions

The entries in this section are **not** new approved rules. They are narrow points that should be annotated during the first table session or confirmed before printing a final rules edition.

Priority	Issue / current handling
Minor	Void Scavenger Speed 5 and Spinecaster Speed 4 remain earlier trial values; not separately signed off.
Minor	Influencer and Engineer base HP 16, and a handful of weapon statistics, remain carried-forward provisional tests.
Timing	An unused Distracted or Exposed expires at end of next allied team activation phase. Clarify how this interacts with a critical opening created on the very last allied activation.
Timing	Read the Situation mirrors Encourage's use-it-or-lose-it timing, with self-use before the Influencer's available turn ends; precise carried-turn case is GM-adjudicated.
Mechanics	An ordinary overlong carbine-mode malfunction was variously described as losing the mode until a new modification and as needing Maintenance. Unlike critical failure (definite Maintenance first), confirm exact recovery cost after overlong mode use.
Mechanics	Jury-Rig enhancement range is initially adjacent equipment; stronger remote variants are future specialization ideas. Signal Scrambler contest duration is contextual.
Mechanics	Overdrive Cellular temporary-HP refresh phrasing (gain 2 per turn capped at 4) may require a concrete tracking example when designing the sheet.

Priority	Issue / current handling
Mechanics	Rules for blocking obstacles/cover geometry, pushing into hazards, impossible pushes, and sharing multiple effects should receive a simple GM ruling as needed.
Design	Damage/healing/conditions on nontypical crits, exact source of noncombat magical range, and interactions of minor illusion with Openings should be adjudicated without granting extra free actions.
Future	Level-three specializations, growth, item progression, vehicle play, technological monster types, and advanced critical outcomes will follow level-one testing.

Important: The four specific critical Create an Opening outcomes are established exactly as reproduced in section 4, with the designer's later Clear Path amendment. The listed open items do not reopen those effects.

ERRATA 01 | CREATE AN OPENING MODIFIERS

Level-One Playtest Rulebook v1 • Rules clarification • Applies to both players and monsters

Core rule: Spend 1 action and choose an Opening before rolling **2d10 + one appropriate base modifier + applicable separate bonuses** against **Target 12**. One attempt per character turn. Choose the base modifier from the method actually used: **weapon/spell attack modifier** for a weapon or offensive ability, or **attribute + relevant skill training** for a maneuver, social tactic, gadget, or other method. **Do not add a weapon attack modifier and skill training again.**

Side	Character / creature	Base bonus	Established ways to calculate the modifier
PLAYERS	**Soldier**	**+3**	Rifle or baton +3; Might +1 + Athletics Trained +2 = +3
	Mutant	**+3**	Melee mutation or Neural Pulse +3; Might +1 + Mobility +2 = +3
	Medic	**+3**	Bio-Rifle or injector +3; Insight +1 + Medicine +2 = +3
	Influencer	**+2 / +3**	Weapons +2; Presence +1 + Influence +2 = +3
	Magi	**+3**	Offensive spell +3; Presence +1 + Occult +2 = +3
	Engineer	**+2 / +3**	Carbine +2 (Stabilized +3); Insight +1 + Technology +2 = +3
MONSTERS	**Void Scavenger**	**+1**	Claws-based setup +1
	Ironhide Brute	**+2**	Slam-based setup +2
	Spinecaster	**+2**	Quills-based setup +2
	Null Warden	**+3 / +2**	Crushing Limb +3; Null Pulse or Shockwave +2

Additional bonuses that can apply

Encourage (Influencer)	+1 to one chosen 2d10 roll, including an ally's Opening; declare before rolling.
Read the Situation (Influencer)	+2 to the Influencer's own Opening attempt against the observed creature.
Other explicit effects	Add applicable bonuses granted by a class ability, equipment, or scenario; numerical bonuses stack unless specified otherwise.

Examples: Soldier uses rifle to Distract: **2d10+3**. Influencer uses persuasion to Expose: **2d10+3**; with Read the Situation and self-Encourage: **2d10+6**. Engineer fires a Stabilized carbine to create an Opening: **2d10+3**. A Null Warden uses Crushing Limb to create an Opening: **2d10+3**.

Scope and limits: A weapon described as the setup method establishes range and attack bonus, but the Opening action itself is not an Attack action and deals no normal weapon damage. Use the weapon/ability's range and line of sight. Unlisted monster non-attack skill/attribute modifiers remain a **GM playtest ruling**—the monster stat blocks do not currently assign those skill bonuses. Ammunition expenditure for a purely narrative setup shot has not been separately established.